THE HITMAKER AND THE HITS
1. Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh; **2.** Pakistan's Bholari airbase, where an Airborne Early Warning & Control aircraft sat inside a hangar that took a direct hit; **3.** multiple F-16s were believed to be damaged after the IAF targeted the main hangar at Jacobabad airbase; **4.** a radar destroyed at Chunian airbase, where a hangar was hit

inside enemy territory. It was the first official affirmation of what many in the military establishment had quietly hinted at since the 88-hour campaign ended on May 10. And yet, the timing raises the obvious question: why now?

The government has always insisted that Operation Sindoor met all its objectives. Supporters of the delayed revelation call it a reaffirmation of victory. Critics see it differently—arguing that such a long wait blunts the psychological and political impact, leaving space for doubt and enemy counter-narratives.

WHY THE DELAY

From the outset, the IAF had maintained—albeit quietly—that it had struck Pakistani jets, citing electronic signatures and strong intelligence. But with no photographic evidence of the wreckage—believed to have fallen on the Pakistani side—the force refrained from making an official statement. Also, electronic warfare data is notoriously difficult to declassify without revealing sensitive methods. But the Director General of Air Operations (DGAO) had mentioned the "kills" during his briefings, while insisting that they had to be confirmed before any final announcement. A senior IAF official, speaking on condition of anonymity, said it took them considerable time to validate the "confirmed kills", collating inputs from multiple surveillance and intelligence systems.

Now, the green light from "higher authorities" seems to have arrived as well. Politically, it couldn't be more convenient. The revelation comes just days after a fierce two-day parliamentary debate on Operation Sindoor, where Opposition MPs questioned India's own losses and hinted at limited success. Similar questions have been repeatedly raised by sections of the western press as well. The government can now point to an unequivocal tally.

Some analysts also note the strategic backdrop: western and Chinese fighter jets are increasingly compared in global military circles. Publicising the destruction of Pakistan's US-supplied F-16s and Chinese-linked systems delivers a subtle message to both camps. It's a replay of 2019, when Wing Commander Abhinandan's MiG-21 reportedly downed a Pakistani F-16, sparking similar debates.

INSIDE THE STRIKES

At Bengaluru, Singh walked the audience through the strikes in almost cinematic detail, with new images showcasing the extensive damage inflicted upon Pakistani military infrastructure. The IAF chief described how a radar installation in Arifwala was destroyed, with the targeting symbology clearly visible in the imagery. At Bholari, an Airborne Early Warning & Control (AEW&C) aircraft sat inside a hangar that took a direct hit, with Pakistani media admitting casualties. Satellite images showed structural damage at the Nur Khan airbase, while at Chunian, a hangar lay in ruins, its scorched frame confirming the strike's precision. At Jacobabad, multiple F-16s were believed to be damaged after the IAF targeted the main hangar.

Singh also revealed what may be India's longest-range surface-to-air kill—a large aircraft shot down at 300 km. It was possibly an ELINT (electronic intelligence) or AEW&C aircraft, the strike made possible by the S-400 air defence system, recently acquired from Russia and what the IAF chief dubbed a "game-changer". Singh stressed that none of Pakistan's jets came anywhere near India's air defence systems such as the Akash and the MRSAM (medium-range surface-to-air missile). He said all enemy aircraft were engaged by

THE AIR CHIEF SPEAKS

Key takeaways from Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh's statement

- **There were "no restrictions" on the military, which was given a free hand to plan and execute Operation Sindoor**
- **Five Pakistani fighter jets shot down by the IAF during Op. Sindoor**
- **"A large aircraft", possibly an ELINT (electronic intelligence) or AEW&C (airborne early warning and control) aircraft, was shot down from 300 km away—"the largest ever recorded surface-to-air kill"**
- **The S-400 surface-to-air missile system was the game-changer for the Indian air defence, scaring off the enemy's fighters**
- **Two command & control centres, six radars destroyed in Murid and Chaklala airbases; runways hit at Sargodha and Rahim Yar Khan airbases**
- **F-16 hangar at Jacobabad airfield hit; UAV hangar at Sukkur airbase damaged; AEW&C hangar at Bholari airbase hit**
- **Op. Sindoor was hi-tech warfare marked by perfect synergy between the services and other agencies**